Card 1: Semicolon between two sentences

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) The bus was late; we missed first period.
B) The bus was late; and we missed first period.

Card 2: Fixing a comma splice

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) Our team practiced all week, we still lost on Friday.
B) Our team practiced all week; we still lost on Friday.

Card 3: Semicolon with however

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) The roads were icy, however; school stayed open.
B) The roads were icy; however, school stayed open.

Card 4: Placing the semicolon

The library closes at three the computer lab stays open until five.

Where does the semicolon belong?

A) after "closes"
B) after "three"
C) after "lab"
D) after "open"

Card 5: What a semicolon can join

Which pair could be joined with a semicolon?

A) Because the game ran late / we got home at midnight
B) After the game / the long drive home
C) The game ran late / we got home at midnight
D) The game ran late / and the drive home

Card 6: Semicolons in a list

Which sentence punctuates the list correctly?

A) We visited Utica, New York; Syracuse, New York; and Rochester, New York.
B) We visited Utica, New York, Syracuse, New York, and Rochester, New York.

Card 7: Colon before a list

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) Bring three things to the exam: a pencil, an eraser, and your ID.
B) Bring: a pencil, an eraser, and your ID.

Card 8: Colon before a list

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) The recipe needs: flour, sugar, and eggs.
B) The recipe needs three ingredients: flour, sugar, and eggs.

Card 9: Colon before an explanation

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) Maya had one goal for the season; a spot on the varsity team.
B) Maya had one goal for the season: a spot on the varsity team.

Card 10: Using a colon correctly

Which sentence uses a colon correctly?

A) My favorite authors are: Stephen King and Jason Reynolds.
B) The forecast called for one thing: snow.
C) We left early because: the roads were bad.
D) The trip included: hiking, fishing, and canoeing.

Card 11: Choosing the mark

The coach posted the starting lineup ___ Jordan, Kayla, Ben, Luis, and Mia.

Which mark belongs in the blank?

A) comma
B) semicolon
C) colon
D) no mark

Card 12: Choosing the mark

The power went out at eight ___ it came back on at midnight.

Which mark belongs in the blank?

A) colon
B) comma
C) no mark
D) semicolon

Card 13: Semicolon with therefore

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) I forgot my calculator; therefore, I borrowed one from Sam.
B) I forgot my calculator, therefore I borrowed one from Sam.

Card 14: Finding the error

Which sentence has a punctuation error?

A) The fair opens Friday; tickets are five dollars.
B) We need two volunteers: one to sell tickets and one to park cars.
C) The barn was old; but it was still standing.
D) Bring the following: boots, gloves, and a hat.

Card 15: Semicolon with a dependent clause

Which sentence uses a semicolon correctly?

A) Although it rained; the game went on.
B) The game went on; although it rained.
C) It rained all afternoon; the game went on anyway.
D) It rained all afternoon; and the game went on.

Card 16: Semicolons in a list

Which sentence is punctuated correctly?

A) The finalists were Ava, a junior, Liam, a sophomore, and Noor, a senior.
B) The finalists were Ava, a junior; Liam, a sophomore; and Noor, a senior.

Card 17: Combining two sentences

The bridge was closed. Drivers took the long way.

Which combines the two sentences correctly?

A) The bridge was closed, drivers took the long way.
B) The bridge was closed: drivers, took the long way.
C) The bridge was closed; drivers took the long way.
D) The bridge was closed; and drivers took the long way.

Card 18: Why a colon works

We had one problem: the bus never came.

Why is the colon correct here?

A) It comes before a list.
B) It joins two sentences with "and."
C) It always follows the word "problem."
D) A complete sentence comes before it, and what follows explains it.

Card 19: Why semicolons work

The tour stops in Albany, New York; Burlington, Vermont; and Boston, Massachusetts.

Why does this list use semicolons?

A) Each item is a complete sentence.
B) The list has more than two items.
C) City names always take semicolons.
D) The items already contain commas.

Card 20: Revising a comma splice

Jon works late, he rarely studies.

Which revision is correct?

A) Jon works late: and he rarely studies.
B) Jon works late; and he rarely studies.
C) Jon works late, he, rarely studies.
D) Jon works late; he rarely studies.

Teacher Key: Semicolons and Colons (scaffolded)

For 10th and 11th grade. Standards are NYS Next Generation ELA; each card practices the 9-10 and 11-12 version of the standard shown.

Card	Skill and standard	Regents	Answer	Why / what to accept
1	Semicolon between two sentences 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**A**	A semicolon replaces the conjunction. With "and" added, the sentence needs a comma instead: "late, and we."
2	Fixing a comma splice 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	Two complete sentences can't be joined with only a comma. That's a comma splice.
3	Semicolon with however 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	The semicolon goes before the transition word and a comma after it.
4	Placing the semicolon 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	"The library closes at three" and "the computer lab stays open until five" are both complete sentences; the semicolon goes between them.
5	What a semicolon can join 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**C**	Only C has a complete sentence on both sides. A starts with "because," so its first half can't stand alone.
6	Semicolons in a list 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**A**	When list items already contain commas, semicolons separate the items so readers can tell where each one ends.
7	Colon before a list 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**A**	A colon needs a complete sentence before it. "Bring" alone can't stand as a sentence.
8	Colon before a list 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	"The recipe needs" is incomplete without its object; "The recipe needs three ingredients" is a complete sentence.
9	Colon before an explanation 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	What follows isn't a complete sentence, so a semicolon can't introduce it. A colon introduces the explanation.
10	Using a colon correctly 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	Only B has a complete sentence before the colon. In A, C, and D, the colon splits a sentence in the middle.
11	Choosing the mark 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**C**	"The coach posted the starting lineup" is complete, and the names that follow are the list it introduces.
12	Choosing the mark 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**D**	Two complete sentences, and the second doesn't explain the first, so a semicolon joins them. A comma would make a comma splice.
13	Semicolon with therefore 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**A**	"Therefore" can't join two sentences by itself. Use a semicolon before it and a comma after it.

Card	Skill and standard	Regents	Answer	Why / what to accept
14	Finding the error 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**C**	With "but," use a comma: "old, but it was." A semicolon replaces the conjunction; it doesn't go with one.
15	Semicolon with a dependent clause 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**C**	"Although it rained" can't stand alone, so A and B are wrong. D adds "and," which needs a comma, not a semicolon.
16	Semicolons in a list 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**B**	Each item already has a comma ("Ava, a junior"), so semicolons separate the three finalists. Without them it looks like six people.
17	Combining two sentences 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**C**	A semicolon joins two complete sentences on its own. A is a comma splice; D adds "and."
18	Why a colon works 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**D**	"We had one problem" is complete, and "the bus never came" explains what the problem was.
19	Why semicolons work 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**D**	Each city-and-state item has its own comma, so semicolons mark where one item ends.
20	Revising a comma splice 9-10L2, 11-12L2: Capitalization, punctuation, and spelling	Control of Conventions (CC)	**D**	A semicolon joins the two complete sentences. A and B add "and" after the mark; C adds commas that don't belong.